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A Lifelong Affair with Inspiration

In my art journey, the diversity of my acquisitions mirrored the expanding horizons of my understanding of art

BY HARSH GOENKA

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Salvador Dalí once said, “A true artist is not one who is inspired, but one who inspires others.” Growing up in Kolkata, surrounded by a rich tapestry of art and culture, it was impossible to not be inspired. Art became a lens through which I viewed the world, and over the years, my fascination only deepened, shaping my understanding of creativity.

In Kolkata, our home was always buzzing with artists, musicians, and thinkers, discussing everything—from brushstrokes to *ragas*—which left an indelible mark on me. My family owned a collection of Indian miniatures, and I was often given the task of cataloguing them. At the time, I found this chore mundane, not realising that it was cultivating artistic nuance.

THE BEGINNING

It wasn’t until 1983, after we moved to Mumbai, that I purchased my first artwork—a painting from M. F. Husain’s ‘Mother Teresa’ series, which cost a then staggering ₹1 lakh. This purchase marked the beginning of a lifelong journey. Soon, I was drawn to the works of other artists like Bikash Bhattacharjee, whose poignant depictions of life left a lasting impression on me.

My collection started with abstract works, gradually expanding into sculptures and installations. The diversity of my acquisitions mirrored the expanding horizons

I no longer sought pieces simply for their visual appeal but started looking for works that challenged me intellectually. I started believing that art should live, breathe, and spark thought. This philosophy led me to display my collection not just in my home, but also in our corporate offices. Art should be accessible, engaging, and stimulating, allowing people from all walks of life to experience its transformative power.

EARLY MISTAKES, LESSONS

Like any collector, I’ve made my fair share of mistakes. In my early days, I bought pieces based on décor. But I



One of the most fascinating aspects of collecting art has been the search for meaning

of my understanding of art. Art, to me, is a reflection of thought, emotion, and sometimes, a cultural movement.

A TURNING POINT

The 1990s marked a significant turning point. That is when my approach to art began to change.

have no hang-ups about them; they were an essential part of my learning.

Each acquisition—whether a mistake or a masterpiece—contributed to the evolution of my tastes.

THE SEARCH FOR MEANING

One of the most fascinating aspects